

YOUR CONDITION · TENDRA

Your neck holds up your head all day. It deserves better.

Why the neck is the most chronically tense region in the body, what is actually causing it, and the small changes that move the needle.

A short read · About 4 minutes · **For anyone who reaches for their neck without thinking about it**

At some point in the last week, you reached up and squeezed the back of your neck without thinking about it. Maybe at the end of a long meeting. Maybe after scrolling for too long. Maybe just driving home. The hand goes up, the thumb digs into the same spot it always does, and there is a familiar grinding tightness that you barely register anymore.

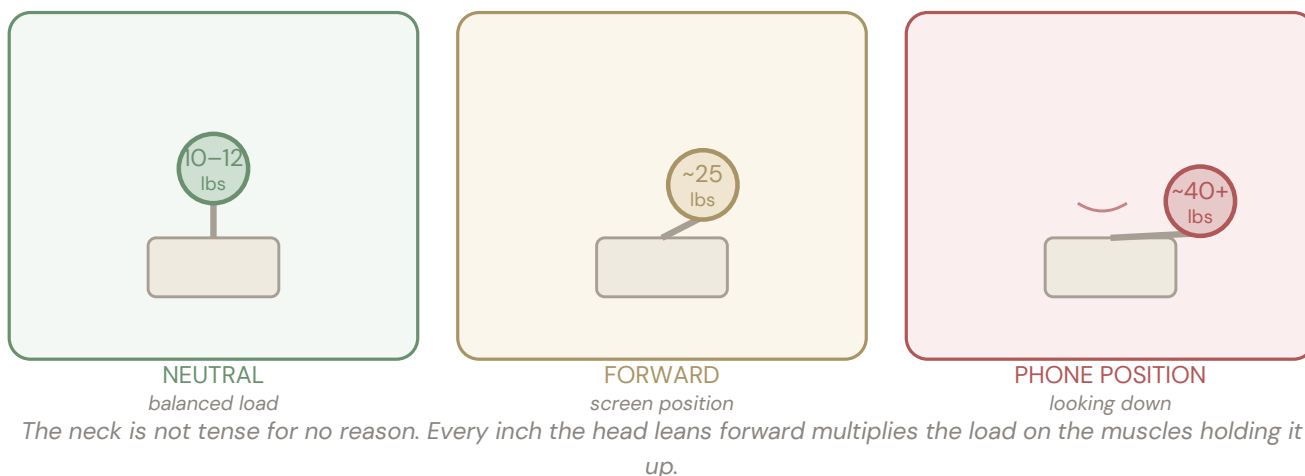
That spot has a story. This article is about what is happening there, why it is so common, and what to do about it.

01 Why the neck takes so much heat

The neck is doing something nothing else in the body has to do. It is holding up roughly ten to twelve pounds — your head — at the end of a fairly thin column of seven vertebrae, all day, for your entire life. It also has to let that ten-pound bowling ball rotate in every direction so you can drive, see your kids, scan a room, type at a screen.

That is already a hard engineering problem. Now add modern life on top of it. The average adult looks down at a phone four to six hours a day. Layer in laptop work, driving, reading. The neck spends most of its waking time bent forward of where it was designed to live.

Here is the part most people are surprised by: every inch the head moves forward of the shoulders multiplies the load on the muscles holding it up. A head held neutral is the ten-to-twelve pound figure. A head leaned forward into a phone position can put something closer to 40 pounds of effective load on those muscles. Sustained for hours, every day, for years.



02 What "neck tension" usually is

Three things, again. The neck has the same general suspects as the lower back, but in different proportions.

Overworked muscles. This is by far the biggest one in the neck. The deep stabilizing muscles at the base of the skull and the broad ones across the top of the shoulders end up doing what posture and structure should be doing. They are not designed for sustained contraction for hours. They protest by getting tight, ropey, and tender to the touch.

Stuck facet joints. Same small joints as in the lower back, just in the neck. When one stops gliding, the surrounding muscles clench around it as a protective response. The clench is the part you feel; the joint is the part causing the clench.

Irritated nerves. Less common, but when it happens it is loud — a sharp pain or tingling that runs into the shoulder, down the arm, sometimes to the fingers. Usually mechanical: a joint or a tight muscle is irritating the nerve as it exits the neck.

03 Why your head hurts too

A large portion of recurring headaches actually originate in the neck. The medical term is "cervicogenic," meaning "of cervical origin," meaning "your neck did this."

The mechanism is straightforward. The top three vertebrae of the neck share nerve pathways with the nerves that supply the back of the head, the temples, and the area behind the eyes. When those joints get restricted and the surrounding muscles get tight, the nervous system can refer pain forward into the head. Patients describe it as a band around the head, a deep ache behind one eye, or a tension that builds through the day and peaks in the evening.

IN PLAIN TERMS

A surprising number of recurring headaches are neck problems wearing a headache costume. Treating the neck often resolves the headache for good.

04 What actually helps

The simplest move: look up. Several times a day, gently tilt the head back and look at the ceiling for ten to twenty seconds. The neck spends so much time looking down that this single motion — done a few times a day — reverses a real fraction of the daily load.

Raise the screen. The top of your monitor should sit at roughly eye level. The phone should come up to your eyes, not the other way around.

Sleep with the right pillow. The pillow should keep the head in roughly the same plane as the spine — not propped up too high, not flattened too low. Stomach sleeping is the worst position because it requires hours of sustained rotation.

Move the neck, gently, often. Slow circles. Side to side. Chin tucks. Motion is the antidote to chronic tension.

Address the stress. The upper trapezius is the body's tension reservoir — it stores emotional load before any other muscle does. Anything that lowers baseline stress tends to drop neck tension within days.

Heat for tight muscles. Heat is generally the right call for chronic-tightness neck pain. Ice is better for new, sharp, inflamed pain. Twenty minutes at a time.

The upper trapezius is the body's tension reservoir. It stores emotional load before any other muscle does. Anything that lowers baseline stress tends to drop neck tension within days.

05 When something is genuinely wrong

CALL THE OFFICE OR SEEK CARE IF YOU NOTICE

- **Numbness, tingling, or weakness in an arm or hand** — especially if it is getting worse.
- **A sudden, severe headache** that feels unlike any familiar headache.
- **Dizziness, vision changes, or trouble with balance or speech** that came on with the neck pain.
- **Neck stiffness with a fever** — uncommon but worth getting looked at the same day.
- **Pain that follows a real injury** — a fall, a car accident — and is not improving over a few days.

For everything else: look up, raise the screen, sleep on a decent pillow, breathe out, and let the practice exercises do their job.

...

About this guide. This is general patient education and is not medical advice for any specific person. The load figures shown are illustrative estimates — the directional point (more forward head = more load) is well-established, but the exact numbers will vary by individual. Any concerns about a specific symptom should go directly to the treating chiropractor or a relevant medical provider.